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Ethical Theory

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Short Assignment

The Grand Inquisitor argues that people can't handle freedom and he basis his argument off human behavior and instinct. His argument takes a rather cynical approach to human behavior. He asserts that if humans are granted free will, they will eventually forgo their freedom or self-destruct. This opposes Mill's idealistic view of human freedom because Mill considers freedom to be a social anarchy. The Grand Inquisitor's view challenges Mill in quite a bold and an even more so realistic manner.

The Grand Inquisitor's argues that natural human tendency is to follow a "universal craving". For instance, humans need to know and be told universally who or what to worship. Without this "universal craving" a person wouldn't know what to believe leading to their own self-destruction. This craving then conflicts with free will because people often give up their freedom in exchange to satisfy this craving or self-destruct. Therefore, it is beneficial to everyone not to have free will.

The Grand Inquisitor illustrates and affirms his argument with the example of Jesus starving forty days in the desert. For instance, Satan offers Jesus the ability to turn rocks into bread so he can eat, but Jesus refuses. Taking Satan's gift would have cost

Jesus' free will which is why he rejected it. The Grand Inquisitor doesn't believe Jesus' actions accurately model human behavior. The Grand Inquisitor is comparing the act of keeping ourselves full as the "universal craving" to the action of accepting or denying Satan's gift as forgoing free will or accepting self-destruction. Therefore, he believes that even Jesus' actions can't justify free will.

I disagree with the Grand Inquisitor because his argument is based off a false premise. His assertion that humans will either forgo free will or self-destruct is false because he is assuming humans are incapable of deciding for themselves who or what they want to worship. He doesn't have the grounds to assert this claim without backing up it up with a more compelling argument and the example he gives isn't sufficient enough for two reasons. The first is that The Grand Inquisitor is comparing a Gilded figure to man and the second is that he doesn't have the right to say self-destruction is something people don't want to worship. Mill's argument is more agreeable because his model leaves room for error and choice to decide what I do or don't want or worship.